time we met, you called me a c*nt.' *Oh, maybe he's all right*, I think, even if he is a farmer and good at batting. We talk for the entire flight.

When we get to India, I'm struggling to find any rhythm and enjoyment. Every time I run in, I feel less like I'm gliding and more like I'm running through some sort of obstacle course, the air thick like sludge and my brain trying to correct all the things in my action I've done so intuitively before as I approach the crease. Despite this, I'm still finding a way to survive, to do enough to stay within selection, and I'm picked for the final Test. Alastair Cook has already scored a very impressive unbeaten hundred on his debut. I'm beginning to like him. I've dyed my hair red now, as if that will help me with being the new bowler they want me to be, like the red might add that extra five miles per hour and get them off my back. In Mumbai, I have catches dropped off my bowling in quick succession against some of the greats; Panesar and Prior in the field putting down Dhoni and Dravid. It isn't particularly helpful, but we continue to fight.

When Sachin Tendulkar walks out to bat, it feels as if the whole of the ground has come to watch him, as if it is he alone that this whole thing is built around. I have been finding it daunting, bowling at the Indian top order anyway – all of them a roll call of names akin to Hollywood stars – Dravid, Sehwag, Dhoni, Laxman – but Tendulkar is another level of aura. The intensity shifts tenfold and as I start to feel the weight of the millions and millions of TV sets being circled around India just to see him, like you can hear them clicking on. I find another level. He loosely drives outside off stump to me and Geraint Jones takes the catch. As I run to celebrate, being in part fortunate to have drawn a false shot from the little master, the odd sensation engulfs the stadium of total, pin-drop silence. People start leaving. Televisions are turned off. It is as if I have spoilt the party before it had started.

Inside the huddle, everything hurting, feeling this continued pinch of out-of-sorts nausea, the silence and the celebration combine to explain something about the psychedelia of my mindset these days. At least, if I ever have children, and they have children, I think to myself, I'll be able to tell them I once got the great man out. They won't ask how. Even if my body does break soon, I'll always have that. I'm not sure if my mind could have taken knowing I would get him out another eight times, the most of any bowler in the history of cricket. I didn't feel like I was that person then.